

AI Literacy

POD 6 - Are we there yet

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So now that you have some familiarity with generative AI and you have seen and even tried out and played with some of the tools that are available and at our fingertips, what's next? When the Ever Given container ship got stuck sideways in the Suez Canal in 2021 because of the strong sideways winds which blew it off course the world's supply lines came to a studdering halt and it took 6 days to get it straight and to restart the marine traffic flowing again. But freeing this giant container ship was started by 2 men and an excavator, digging a trench on the canal bank in order to free up the bow of the ship. Afterwards, the big tugboats and so on were able to do their thing with pulleys and so on, but the whole operation was started small: 2 men and a digger.

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We're not saying that generative AI is like a container ship stuck in a canal, but with every major change we encounter in life, a really comfortable way to change is to change slowly, and to start small, and that's what you should do with generative AI - just like the ship stuck in the canal, start small. Start using generative AI somewhere, but start small and start now. For example, use Perplexity.ai which you have seen earlier, instead of Google when you want to do a search for some broad information that isn't time-sensitive or urgent, something like when you want to know what is the best time of year to go on holidays to Disneyland or how is the game of Shinty played. A second thing you can do is, for example, if you want to find out what you can do with crab apples because you've a windfall of them in your garden don't just ask ChatGPT but also ask Google's Gemini or Claude.ai or Microsoft's Copilot, just to see and to compare the different answers that they give, again just like the example which you saw earlier in the course.



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Finally, take some long documents that you would like to read, but nothing that's work-related or sensitive, and upload them to one of the large language models and then ask questions about the document. And when you do that you will then be fine tuning an underlying foundational model and you will see how easy it was to do. So apart from starting small and getting familiar with using Generative AI yourself, there's two additional points we would like to add that we believe are important. The first of these is about jobs and about AI taking over the world and replacing people. People sometimes ask, will AI take over my job and replace me? History shows that with every great disruption comes a period of extreme uncertainty and fear and that is where many of us are now with generative AI. It is not the AI that scares some people, it is the concept of change, and the fear of the unknown. AI cannot replace jobs which require levels of human interaction, creativity, emotional intelligence, or even physical dexterity. AI can replace some of our tasks, but not our jobs, because it can help with some of our activities, but not our roles.

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Our intelligence and our creativity is a chaotic interplay of ideas and thoughts which come from our own memories, our skills, our knowledge, our wisdom, and our experiences, and our own emotions. Generative AI is only a mimic of human output which it has learned from its training data, but it comes from a completely different process to the way that we learned and while it can replicate some human outputs, it cannot replicate our human thought processes. It can generate images, it can generate words, but it does not capture the deep thinking that comes from human creativity. And, it does make a compelling case to be used as our partner in creativity as our collaborator. The second of the important points we would like to make is about continuous learning. The field of Artificial Intelligence is constantly evolving, and it is moving at a very fast pace, a pace which is uncomfortably fast for some of us. There are new technologies and new applications emerging regularly, almost every week. And we need to stay up-to-date with AI trends and best practices because the barriers to actually accessing and using these AI techniques are almost



non-existent. Almost anyone with access to the internet has access to the new forms of AI and that allows many people to participate in using Artificial Intelligence.

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This all makes continuous learning and upskilling essential for us if we want to keep on top of things. So to comfortably address these two points about jobs and AI and about how fast-moving the developments are, there are two things that we must do when we are using Artificial Intelligence. And these are firstly, to build up our own digital literacy and secondly to always have a human in the loop when we use AI. By completing this course, hopefully you will have already enhanced your understanding of AI and you will also recognise that when using AI we should always have it working for us, it giving us assistance and helping us, but it is us who remain in control. Thanks for taking the course, we hope you found it useful and remember, when it comes to artificial intelligence your learning is never finished, you have only just started. Take care.